Delegate Background Guide

UNCSW

UNITED NATIONS COMMISSION ON THE STATUS OF WOMEN

Dismantling the Imperial Class and Rectifying the Structural Deficit of Women's Empowerment in C-Suite Leadership and Corporate Governance

BACKGROUND GUIDE

Prepared for delegates | MEA

NGPC'26

VOCI DEI GIOVANI, CRISI GLOBALI

Letter from the Dais

Honourable Delegates,

Welcome to the United Nations Commission on the Status of Women. Leadership at the highest levels of business shapes wages, workplace culture, investment priorities, and the distribution of economic power. Women have made progress in education and employment, yet barriers often remain in promotion, access to networks, caregiving support, financing, and representation on boards and in executive positions.

The phrase “imperial class” in the agenda needs careful definition during debate. Delegates may interpret it as entrenched elite power and closed decision-making networks that limit access to corporate leadership. Whatever definition you choose, state it clearly, avoid unsupported assumptions, and focus on measurable structural barriers.

We encourage you to explore transparent promotion systems, accountability, equal pay, anti-harassment protections, inclusive board recruitment, mentoring, and work-life policies. The goal is not only representation but fair access to authority, resources, and meaningful decision-making.

Sincerely,
The Dais

Introduction to UNCSW

The Commission on the Status of Women (CSW) is a functional commission of ECOSOC and the principal intergovernmental body dedicated to gender equality and the empowerment of women. It reviews progress, identifies challenges, and makes recommendations to advance women's rights. UN Women supports the Commission and works with governments and civil society on gender equality.

On this agenda, delegates examine the barriers to women's participation in C-suite roles, such as chief executive officer, chief financial officer, chief operating officer, and other senior executive positions, as well as in corporate governance, including board membership and oversight. The committee should recognize differences across regions, sectors, company sizes, and legal systems. It should also consider intersecting barriers linked to disability, ethnicity, class, migration status, caregiving, and access to education and professional networks.

Introduction to the Agenda

Corporate leadership influences organizational strategy, hiring, pay, investment, and accountability. When women are underrepresented in senior executive positions or on boards, organizations may lose talent and decision-making can reflect a narrower range of experiences. However, increasing representation requires more than appointing a small number of women; it requires changing the systems that determine recruitment, promotion, compensation, retention, and authority.

Structural barriers can include opaque promotion criteria, gender stereotypes, unequal caregiving expectations, workplace harassment, limited access to influential networks, biased performance assessments, pay gaps, and weak accountability. Women from marginalized groups may face overlapping barriers. The phrase "imperial class" is not a standard UN legal term, so delegates should define it in committee, potentially as entrenched elite networks or concentrated corporate power that restrict access to leadership, and avoid treating it as a settled technical concept.

> **Possible approaches include transparent recruitment and promotion, board diversity targets or quotas where appropriate, pay audits, parental leave, affordable childcare, anti-harassment systems, mentorship and sponsorship, public reporting, and stronger access to capital for women entrepreneurs. Policies should be evaluated by their outcomes, not only by written commitments.**

Key Terms

TERM	DEFINITION
C-suite	A group of senior executives whose titles commonly begin with "Chief," such as CEO, CFO, or COO.

TERM	DEFINITION
Corporate governance	The systems and processes through which companies are directed, monitored, and held accountable.
Gender pay gap	A difference between the average earnings of women and men, which may reflect multiple factors and does not by itself prove unequal pay for equal work.
Glass ceiling	Invisible or systemic barriers that limit advancement into senior leadership.
Sticky floor	Conditions that keep workers, often women, in low-paid or low-mobility roles.
Unpaid care work	Caregiving and household work that is unpaid and often unevenly distributed.
Board diversity	Representation of different genders and backgrounds on a company's governing board.
Sponsorship	Active advocacy by a senior person to help another person access opportunities and advancement.
Intersectionality	The way different forms of inequality can interact and shape people's experiences.

Key Issues

1. Recruitment and promotion bias

Informal criteria and subjective evaluations can reproduce existing leadership patterns. Structured interviews, published criteria, diverse shortlists, and promotion audits can improve fairness.

2. Caregiving and work design

Long-hours expectations and limited childcare or parental leave can penalize workers with caregiving responsibilities. Flexible work should not become a path to lower visibility or slower promotion.

3. Pay transparency and accountability

Without reliable pay data, disparities may remain hidden. Pay audits and transparent salary bands can identify issues while protecting personal information.

4. Board representation and tokenism

Targets may increase representation but do not guarantee influence. Delegates should consider committee assignments, leadership roles, independence, and whether women hold genuine decision-making power.

5. Harassment and workplace safety
Sexual harassment, retaliation, and hostile workplace cultures can push women out of leadership pipelines. Confidential reporting, independent investigations, and protection against retaliation are essential.

6. Networks, capital, and mentorship
Access to sponsors, investors, high-profile assignments, and professional networks affects advancement. Mentorship alone is insufficient without fair access to strategic roles and resources.

7. Intersectional inequality and data
Women are not a uniform group. Data should be disaggregated where safe and lawful, and policies should consider disability, ethnicity, class, nationality, and sector.

8. Defining "imperial class"
The agenda uses a non-standard phrase. Delegates should agree on a clear working definition, such as entrenched elite networks or concentrated corporate power, before proposing policy measures.

Major Stakeholders

Member States and labour ministries
Set equality, employment, reporting, and anti-discrimination laws.

Commission on the Status of Women and UN Women
Advance international gender-equality commitments and support policy dialogue.

Corporate boards and executive teams
Set governance, recruitment, pay, and workplace-culture practices.

Shareholders and institutional investors
Can ask for disclosure, accountability, and governance improvements.

Workers' organizations and professional associations
Represent workers and support fair workplace practices.

Civil society and gender-equality organizations
Monitor progress, provide research, and advocate for change.

Business schools and training providers
Support leadership development and address bias in professional pathways.

Care providers and public services
Affordable childcare and care infrastructure can expand access to employment and leadership.

Past International Actions and Frameworks

Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW, 1979)
Requires States Parties to address discrimination against women across public and private life.

Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action (1995)
Sets a global agenda for women's rights and identifies women in power and decision-making as a critical area.

ILO Equal Remuneration Convention (No. 100, 1951)
Addresses equal remuneration for men and women for work of equal value.

ILO Discrimination (Employment and Occupation) Convention (No. 111, 1958)
Addresses discrimination in employment and occupation.

Sustainable Development Goal 5
Calls for gender equality and for women's full and effective participation and equal opportunities for leadership.

UN Women's leadership work
Provides data, research, and policy resources on women's leadership and participation.

Corporate governance codes and disclosure rules
National approaches vary; many use board diversity reporting, targets, or other accountability measures.

Timeline

DATE	DEVELOPMENT
1946	Commission on the Status of Women established.
1979	CEDAW adopted by the UN General Assembly.
1995	Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action adopted.
2000	Millennium Development Goals include gender equality and women's empowerment.
2015	Sustainable Development Goal 5 adopted as part of the 2030 Agenda.
2020	The Beijing+25 process reviews progress and persistent barriers.
2023–2026	Governments, investors, and international bodies continue to debate board diversity, pay transparency, care systems, and corporate accountability; verify the latest country-specific rules before citing them.

Key Questions a Resolution Must Answer

1. How should the committee define "imperial class" in a clear, measurable, and non-discriminatory way?
2. Should countries adopt binding quotas, voluntary targets, disclosure rules, or a mix of approaches for board representation?

3. How can promotion criteria and pay structures be made transparent without exposing sensitive personal data?
4. What safeguards can prevent harassment and retaliation against women who report misconduct?
5. How can public policy and employers share responsibility for childcare and other care infrastructure?
6. How can representation be measured alongside decision-making power, pay, retention, and promotion outcomes?

Bibliography and Further Reading

Use these official and institutional sources as starting points, and check the latest documents before citing statistics or claiming that a policy is current.

UN Women – Leadership and Political Participation
https://www.unwomen.org/en/what-we-do/leadership-and-political-participation

UN Women Data Hub
https://data.unwomen.org/

OHCHR – CEDAW
https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/convention-elimination-all-forms-discrimination-against-women

Beijing Platform for Action
https://www.un.org/womenwatch/daw/beijing/platform/

ILO – Equality and Discrimination
https://www.ilo.org/topics-and-sectors/equality-and-discrimination

UN Sustainable Development Goal 5
https://sdgs.un.org/goals/goal5

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